and are thus impure. The Sabarimala temple board even claims to have introduced a scanning machine that detects any menstruating woman, and is supported in this by the Travancore Devaswom Board, which argues that banning menstruating women is a centuries-old religious practice – an argument which in April 2016 was declared discriminatory and thus unconstitutional by the Indian Supreme Court.

Ask who Lord Ayyappan is and you will get conflicting answers. By the most popular account, he is the adopted son of a raja who grew up to become a great warrior and protector but then chose to retire to the forest, after asking the king to build a temple at Sabarimala and install his image there. Another account makes him the son of the god Harihara, a fused form of Vishnu and Shiva, whose image first appeared in stone in the sixth century at the cave-temples of Badami, the capital of the Chalukya rulers of Karnataka. A third explanation is that he is an ancient personification of nature, while a fourth equates him with Ayyanar, the guardian protector deity whose fierce life-size terracotta images can be seen, most often mounted on a horse or an elephant, on the outskirts of many villages in Tamil Nadu. This last would seem the most plausible – but there is also a fifth explanation, which begins with the clue that in Kerala Ayyappan also goes by the name of Dharmashasta, 'teacher of the Dharma'.

This blurring of origins matters not a jot to Lord Ayyappan's cheerful devotees, many drawn from the poorer sections of society. Yet I suspect they might be surprised to learn that some of their ancestors might well have been Buddhists, or that Sabarimala may have begun as a Buddhist shrine, that the name of the god they worship as Shasta or Dharmashasta was formerly applied to the Buddha, and that the mantra they chant – *Swamiye saranam Ayyappa!*, 'I take refuge in Lord Ayyappan' – could